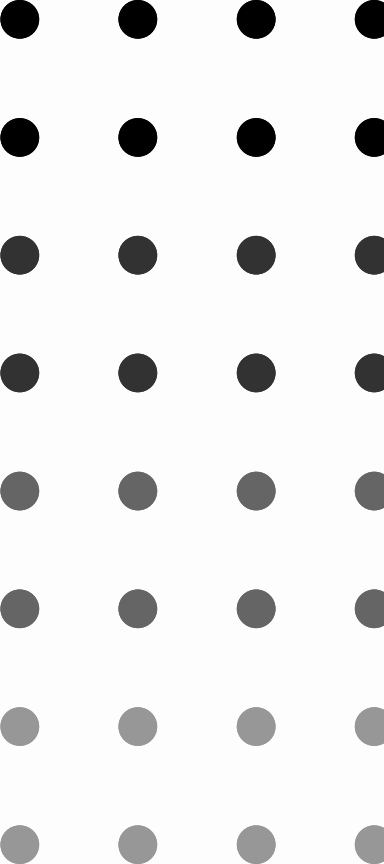




K-12 SCHOOL RATINGS

Understanding how parents
interpret school ratings

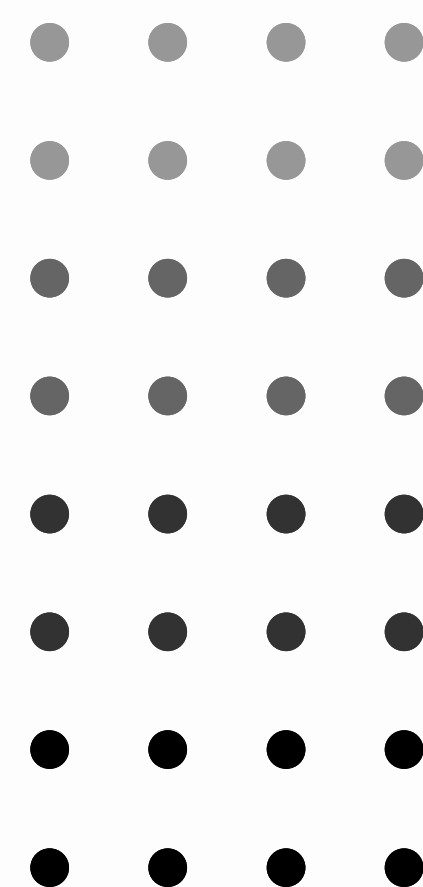


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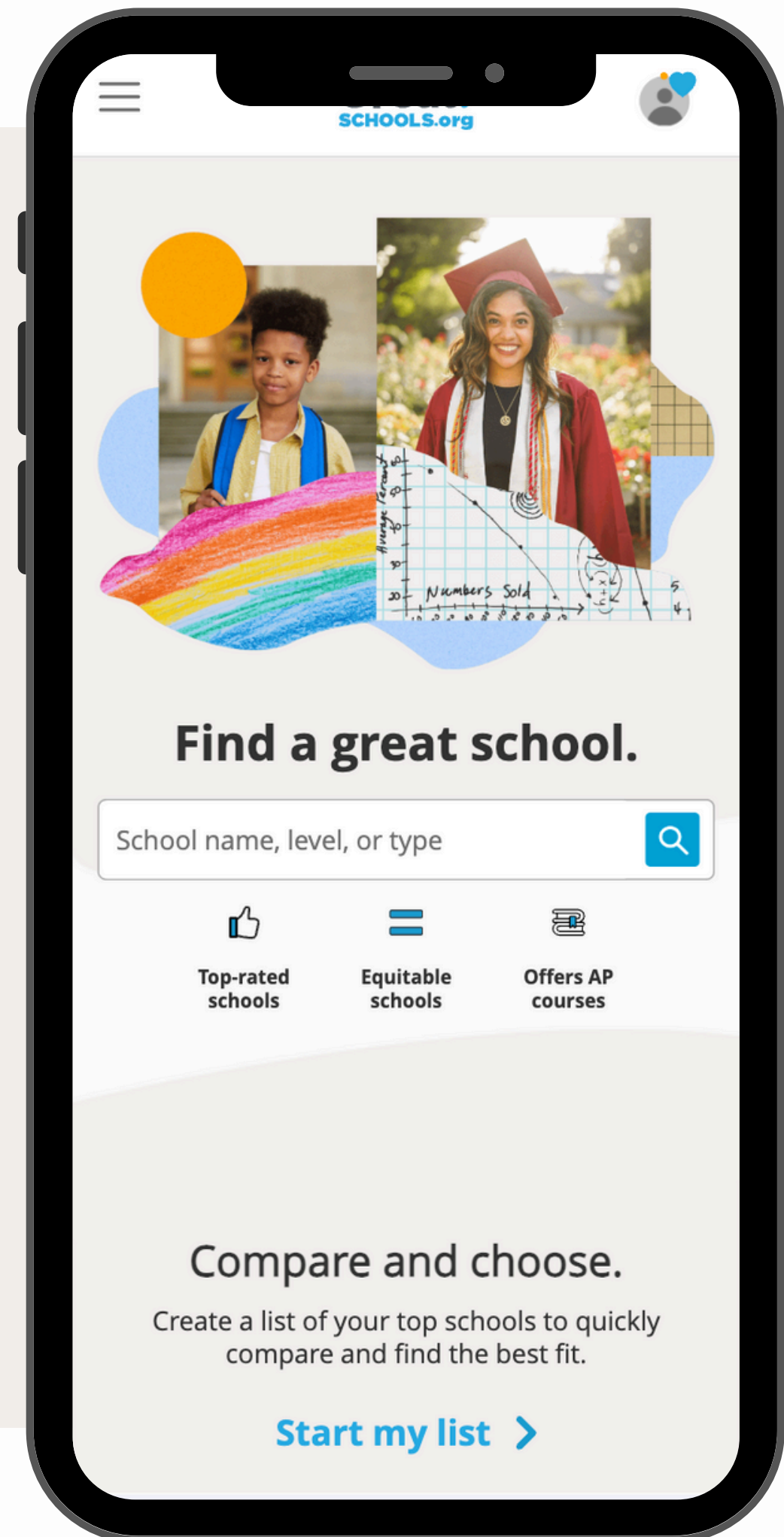
BUSINESS CONTEXT

- 25 year old non-profit organization
- Only 35 employees
 - 1 designer, 1 UX researcher
- Multiple products
 - API (e.g., Zillow integration)
 - Database of K-12 school quality info

The logo for Great!SCHOOLS.org is displayed on a blue rectangular background. The word "Great!" is in a large, white, sans-serif font, and "SCHOOLS.org" is in a smaller, white, sans-serif font below it.

PRIOR RESEARCH

- Personas
 - Parents
 - Real estate agents
 - School employees
 - Other
- Jobs-to-be-done
 - Finding the best school
 - Depth of research varies
 - Power users vs. data triangulators
- Journey map
 - Highly emotional, very stressful
 - Priorities change

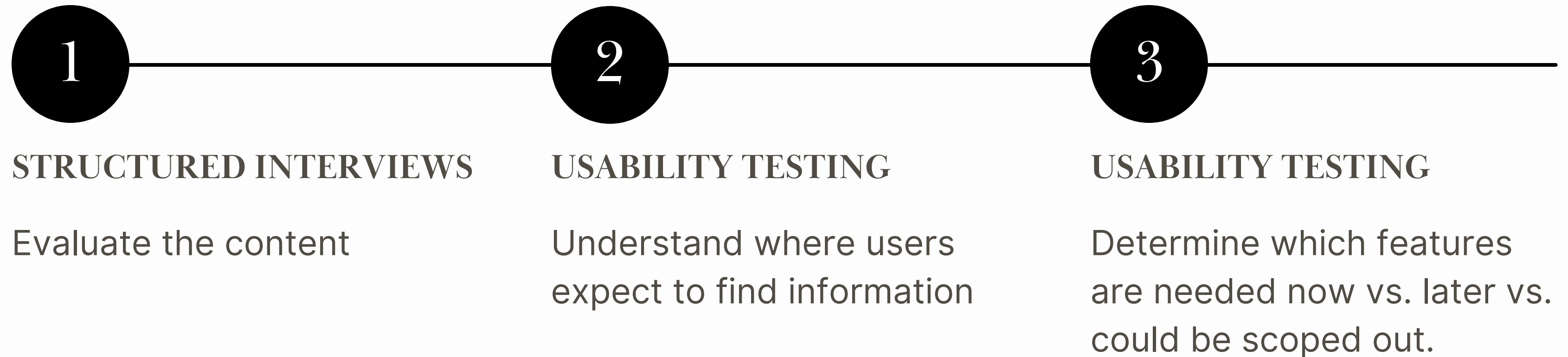


RESEARCH QUESTIONS

- Prior research covered who, what, when, why
- But did not explore the *how*
 - 1. What info about ratings is needed to pick a school?
 - 2. Can parents comprehend that information?

TIMELINE

- Team wanted final designs in ~3 weeks
- We had no content employees



STRUCTURED INTERVIEWS

- 1:1 User interviews
 - Designed a Jeopardy-style activity
 - Columns represent data on school profiles
 - Rows represent follow-up questions
 - Invited participants to select a few cards
 - Forcing them to prioritize, show importance
 - After selecting a card, read aloud, then responded
 - Showing if content was comprehensible
- Recruitment (n=5)
 - Screened to find parents looking for a new school

	School ratings		
	Test scores	College readiness	
What is the score?	8/10 above average	5/10 average	
What does the score represent?			
Why does this topic matter?			
How are other schools performing?			
What data was used?			
Why was this data used?			
How old is this data?			

COMMUNICATION

- Stakeholders weren't excited about this research
- I anticipated difficulties getting buy-in
- I prepared by
 - Asking stakeholders about their concerns
 - "Soft-launching" insights so PMs wouldn't be surprised
- I used different communication styles
 - Zoom calls, Slack Huddles
 - Tables in Confluence page
 - Slide decks

Finding	Impact
Some answers were understandable, but led to new questions.	Validated decision to use progressive disclosure.
One new question came up.	Drafted content, conducted usability test.
One answer was disappointing - users didn't want schools to be compared across the entire state.	Product roadmap was adjusted because users are asking "is there a better school my child can attend" not "which school is the best in our state".
Clear understanding of what data is needed for users' JTBD.	Rolled out to all users in September 2024 • 3-5 million school profiles viewed/month • 600k more clicks in May 2025

CONCLUSION

- Stakeholder management
 - Identified gap in previous research
 - Persuaded stakeholders that research was necessary
- Research prioritization & planning
 - Scoped the project, given the time frame
 - Identified how to get clean data quickly
- Creating business impact
 - Improved usability & increased engagement opportunities
 - Prioritized & scoped other recommendations
 - Advocated for adjustment of product roadmap



CREDITS

Title slide	Hayyan Creative Studio
Deck template	Saga Design Studio
Headshot	Framed By Two